



NEWS

Bus Stops Here: Shanghai Lets Riders Design Their Own Routes

A new crowd-sourced transit platform allows riders to propose, vote on, and activate new bus lines in as little as three days.



By *Chen Yiru*

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From early-morning school drop-offs to seniors booking rides to the hospital, from suburban commuters seeking a faster link to the metro to families visiting ancestral graves, Shanghai is rolling out a new kind of public bus — one that's designed by commuters, and launched only when enough riders request it.

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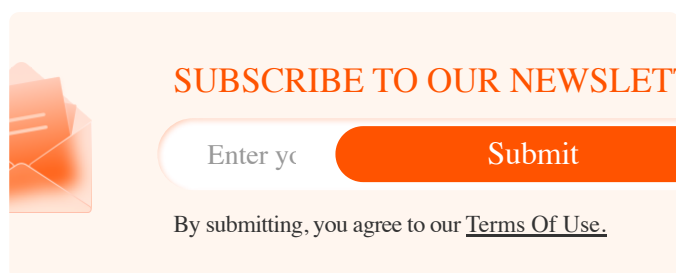
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gzh, or “customized,” the

system invites residents to submit proposed routes through a city-run platform. Others with similar travel needs can opt in or vote, and if demand meets the threshold — typically 15 to 20 passengers per trip — the route goes live.

More than 220 DZ routes have already launched across all 16 city districts. Through an online platform opened May 8, users enter start and end points, preferred times, and trip frequency. If approved, routes can begin running in as little as three days.



Screenshots of the new customized bus platform. From Weibo

One of the first test cases was DZ301, a pilot route linking a major metro station with surrounding residential blocks, schools, and office buildings. “The average daily passenger flow is 250 to 260 people — 170 to 180 during the morning peak and 70 to 80 in the evening,”

Company, [told](#) domestic media.

The route originated from a resident's request submitted last December. In response, transit staff conducted on-site research, observing foot traffic, speaking with commuters, and calculating turnover times during peak hours. Drivers then ran trial runs to fine-tune the schedule before the route officially launched.

Chen Xiaohong, a professor at Tongji University's School of Transportation, said the system builds on Shanghai's dense transit network to better match capacity with demand, improving both convenience and resource use during peak travel.

Proposed routes appear on a "Popular Customization" page, where others can opt in to help reach the launch threshold. Group bookings can also fast-track approval. Fares are market-based, and while they follow basic public transit standards, no discounts are currently offered for students, seniors, or other groups.

Wang Yixiang, deputy director of the city's Passenger Transport Department, [said](#) the new platform shortens what was once a slow, bureaucratic process for launching new routes. But he acknowledged early challenges: passenger demand is uneven, public awareness remains low, and planning still relies heavily on manual fieldwork.

"Going forward, we need to improve route

platform functions, and

g said.

(Header image: A “DZ” bus arrives at a residential area in Shanghai, 2025. From Weibo)



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